

all believers, irrespective of religion, to be allowed unrestricted entry into its premises. This has enflamed passions, with those in favour and those opposed to it being almost equally divided.

The debate over denial of entry into temples is not new in the country—the late prime minister Indira Gandhi was turned away from Puri's Jagannath temple because she was married to a Parsi. Elsewhere in Kerala, while the Sabarimala temple allows entry to all irrespective of religion or caste, its doors remain closed for women of menstrual age. Controversy has hounded the Guruvayoor temple earlier too when it barred K.J. Yesudas, a Catholic, from its precincts though the ace playback singer, a Sri Krishna devotee, has cut several devotional discs about the temple and its presiding deity. His music is even played at the temple every day.

Controversy was heightened last week following a purification ceremony conducted inside the temple after the ceremonial first feeding of the grandson of Vayalar Ravi, Union Minister for Overseas Indian Affairs.

The purification was conducted by tantr (high priest) Chenas Raman Nampoothiri because the child's grandmother, Mercy Ravi, is a Christian. Interestingly, a similar ceremony was conducted by the temple seven years ago after Ravi's son Ravi Krishna's marriage was solemnised here. "More than angry, I am saddened. They did it after my son's marriage and now they do it to my next generation. This is an insult. My son and his wife are Hindus and so is their child," said Ravi. "I have formally complained to the Devaswom Board (a state government-appointed trust that runs the temple). If there is no other course of action left, I will approach the court as the *punyaham* (purification) is a restriction on my fundamental right to practise any religion," said Krishna, who is a Mumbai-based lawyer.

But the temple priests hold that they don't know if Krishna is a Hindu for the temple laws do not clearly say whether the progeny of a Hindu father and a non-Hindu mother is a Hindu.

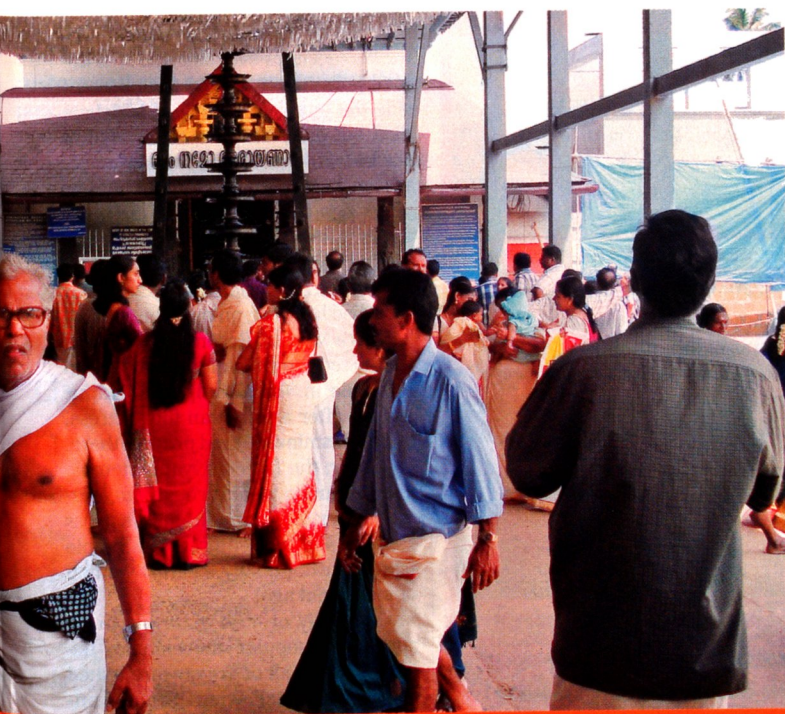
NO ENTRY: The Guruvayur temple is closed to all non-Hindus

"Mercy may be a Christian but our wedding was held according to Hindu rites. As Ezhavas, we follow the patrilineal system by which the son follows the father's religion," says Ravi. Even Krishna's school records show his religion as Hindu. The issue is quite emotional for the Vayalars since the child was born after the death of Krishna's first child two years ago. "Lord Guruvayoorappan answered our prayers for a second child and that's why we came here," says Krishna.

In Kerala, where no issue is without a political twist, politicians jumped into the fray. "It is a shame not just to Hindus but to the entire nation to have such archaic and barbaric rituals," said Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan. He points out that Kerala is far ahead of the rest of the country on social indices only because of the early reforms against casteism and religious bigotry. G. Sudhakaran, minister for temple administration, has told tantris that they are working against the law and the Constitution by denying entry to believers and practising untouchability. "We will initiate prosecution against the tantr if Vayalar Ravi lodges a formal complaint," he says.

The ruling CPI(M)'s youth wing has launched a second Guruvayur Satyagraha to lift the ban on all believers, but some Hindu groups have warned against any moves to change temple traditions and customs. Though parties like the BJP and the VHP agree that changes in rituals are required to suit the changing times, they oppose a secular government's attempts to meddle in temple affairs. "Let reforms be discussed and decided by Hindu believers, priests, and acharyas. Why does the Government target only temples? Does the Government or the CPI(M) have the guts to interfere in the religious rituals of Christians or Muslims? Can they ask Muslims to do away with restrictions on women in mosques?" asks P.K. Krishnadas, BJP state president. "We suspect the intentions of the Leftists; they have an agenda to destroy Hindu institutions and organisations."

At the same time, the Yogakshema Sabha—the Brahmin community group of which the Guruvayur tantris are members—has initiated internal discussions to bring about suitable



Backward caste Hindu groups supporting changes in customs.